the Soviet trade deal, Apel returned to his office at the House of Ministries and shot himself. A 7.65 mm bullet from his service pistol lay at his feet.

In the hours and days that followed, wild rumours abounded about the death, some suspected Apel had been murdered in a power struggle between Politburo members, while Günther Wyschofsky, one of his deputies, later revealed seeing several bullet holes in the office. The clues prompted little action during a three-day MfS probe, described as being ‘uncharacteristically sloppy’. Inevitably, within a couple of days, Willy Brandt – who liked to blow on the coals – made his feelings known, telling West German radio there was no doubt that Apel’s death had been a suicide, performed in protest over Moscow’s continuing exploitation of the GDR. East Berlin tried to grab back the microphone by issuing a furious rebuttal on air and in Neues Deutschland, in a piece almost certainly hastily penned by Honecker:

Brandt’s attempt to misuse the death of Comrade Apel for anti-Soviet propaganda is condemned to failure since all GDR citizens are well-informed on the results of the most recent trip of our party-government delegation to the USSR and on the contents of the great long-term USSR-GDR trade agreement. Everyone is aware that Comrade Apel had a great share in the grandiose results of our delegation and in the conclusion of the trade agreement.

Is it not deeply humiliating for Brandt, who pretends to be a politician, to make himself the hawker of the lies of those scribblers who have always behaved like political vultures?

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